





MOVING TARGETS (Clockwise from L) The hexacopter that was shot down in Talia Haria Chak, Kathua, May 29; sticky bombs and UBGLs that were recovered

Photographs by ANI

J&K

A STICKY FORM OF TERROR

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

Long before the US withdrew its troops from Afghanistan in August 2021, Taliban insurgents were using this guerrilla tactic to subvert its ground strength and set off bursts of violent mayhem. That too with a simple device: small sticky bombs planted on vehicles carting the enemy. Inspired by its success, Kashmir is now witnessing the entry of this new weapon of offence alongside a shift in the tactical armoury of militancy itself.

Security forces woke up to the threat after a drone consignment was recovered in Samba along the LoC on February 14. Cheap and portable, a sticky bomb packs RDX or TNT into a small box, has a magnet to fix it to the target metal surface, and is detonated remotely with a timer. The security establishment is a bit spooked by the spectre because it can change the rules of engagement in the Valley—especially since planting these IEDs needs no special training. "It just needs two open wires to be connected to activate a blast," says Jammu ADGP Mukesh Singh. Hence, the skill threshold needed to carry out blasts like the one on May 13—when a bomb affixed to the fuel tank of a pilgrim bus en route to Vaishno Devi killed four and left nearly two dozen wounded—is considerably lowered.

Originally developed as an anti-tank weapon by the British army during World War II, sticky bombs found their way into the Afghan war—and, in its wake, have now travelled further east. Not that it was entirely unknown in India: it was a sticky bomb affixed to a car that had left an Israeli diplomat's wife wounded in New Delhi in February 2012. But it's now being increasingly felt as a threat on the ground in a new battlefield: Kashmir. On March 9, a civilian was killed and 16 injured in a crowded market of Udhampur, Jammu. It took the J&K police two and a half months to track down the alleged culprit, Mohammad Ramzan Sohil of Halla Bohar Dhar in Ramban district. He had apparently detonated a sticky bomb on the directions of Pakistan-based Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) militant Mohammad Amin 'Khubaib'. Two more magnet bombs were recovered from two others, Khurshed Ahmed of Motla Dessa and Nisar Ahmed Khan of Bhaderwah, says ADGP Singh.

On May 29, a North Korean hexacopter with a payload of seven sticky bombs and a UBGL (under barrel grenade launcher) was shot down in